

States **BIHAR**

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

Two tarred signboards and pin-drop silence in a vast landscape now mark the site of the proposed electric locomotive workshop in Bihar's Madhepura district. Former railway minister Lalu Prasad Yadav had planned to set up the Rs 1,300-crore project in his erstwhile parliamentary constituency. "This (workshop) will help in all-round development of the backward areas of the north-eastern region and north Bihar," said Lalu in his Budget speech on February 26, 2007.

The ground reality, however, contradicts what Lalu had promised even though Chief Public Relations Officer of East Central Railways A.K. Chandra claims otherwise. "All these projects are on. Land acquisition is in progress and adequate allotments have been made for the current fiscal," Chandra told INDIA TODAY. The state government officials who have to finally settle the acquired land in favour of the Railways offer a different version though. "The railway officials are yet to approach us for the mutation of the acquired land," says Sushil Kumar, land requisition deputy collector, Madhepura. The land

Lalu DERAILED

Worth Rs 55,000 crore, the former railway minister's initiatives for his home state are gathering dust now

acquisition process holds no meaning without mutation, which is the transfer of legal rights of the acquired land and it happens only after completion of the compensation process. The Madhepura factory will require around 450 hectares of land. Interestingly, in February 2008, the Railway Act was amended to empower the ministry for acquisition of land by itself for important railway projects. The Bihar Government, therefore, has no role in the land acquisition process being carried out by railway officials in Bihar.

The Madhepura factory is one of the several railway projects worth Rs 55,000 crore that Lalu had sanctioned as railway minister. Apart from the wheel factory at Chapra, most of these projects—diesel locomotive fac-

tory at Marhaura, goods wagon repair workshop at Sonapur, diesel multiple unit maintenance depot at Sonapur, wagon repair workshop at Samastipur and concrete sleeper factories at Madhepura, Sitamarhi and Chaksikandar—are gathering dust now. These initiatives would have generated huge employment opportunities in the state. The diesel factory at Marhaura alone is said to have the potential of employing over 7,000 while the wheel plant at Chapra may absorb around 1,100. Though the new Railway Minister Mamata Banerjee has not glibly disowned her predecessor's projects, Lalu's exit from the ministry followed by the apparent loss of Bihar clout at the Centre seems to have put many Bihar-centric railway projects in

Running Out of Steam



AMIT KUMAR

Project

Rs 1,300-crore electric locomotive workshop at Madhepura, sanctioned in February 2009

STATUS

Land acquisition yet to be finished. Railways yet to approach district officials for formal mutation.



KM KISHAN

Project

Rs 2,025-crore diesel locomotive factory at Marhaura and Chapra, approved in February 2009

STATUS

Some land acquired, but no mutation done. Hardly any progress at the ground level.



Project

Rs 1,000-crore wheel factory at Chapra, the constituency Lalu represents in the Lok Sabha